OFFICIAL PROGRAM & RULES

THE INTERNATIONAL SPACE DOG SHOW

A Travelling Exhibition of Pets, Mascots, and Companion Creatures from Every Corner of Wildspace

Hosted this cycle at the Floating Pavilion, three days' sail coreward of the Rock of Bral.
All chartered crews, independent operators, and persons of quality welcome to enter.
Entrants need not be dogs. Entrants need not, strictly, be animals. The judges have seen worse.

What This Show Actually Is

Founded some one hundred and eighty years ago by the astral elf Ophelia Rask, who grew tired of watching the founding houses turn every gathering into a negotiating table and wanted one event where that was expressly, formally forbidden. Lady Rask presides still, the Astral Kennel Concordance having run the Show every cycle since under her own continued eye, and the no-business rule still holds on the judging floor, by long tradition rather than any enforceable law, which has somehow made it stick harder than a law would have.

It has become, almost by accident, the one place in known space where rival houses, independent crews, and everyone between them stand shoulder to shoulder and mean it, if only for the length of a judging round. Attendance is itself a kind of status. Winning, even a minor category, follows a name for seasons. One hundred and eighty years is long enough that nobody alive remembers a Wildspace without it.

This Cycle's Categories

Physical Lane, bracketed by size class (Tiny through Huge)

Best Presentation — *sponsored by House Delverane*
Coat, scale, carapace, plumage, whatever the species in question actually has, judged against its own kind's standard, never cross-species.

The Long Run — *sponsored by House Stoneward*
A timed obstacle course run in full gravity-plane conditions. Speed and composure both count.

The Proving Round — *sponsored by House Stoneward*
A supervised sparring trial between willing, evenly matched entrants, judged on skill and control. Ends at the first clean hit or clear dominance. No serious harm permitted.

Strength of Pull — *sponsored by House Stoneward*
A straightforward hauling and towing trial. Raw power, nothing more.

Fastest in Show — *sponsored by House Delverane*
A straight sprint, no obstacles, no course, just speed.

The Cargo Run — *sponsored by House Stoneward*
Hauling a sandbag load from one post to another and back. Strength and endurance both, judged on pace held, not a burst of it.

Open Field, species and size both irrelevant

Most Convincing Trick — *sponsored by House Vellum*
A trick is convincing if the record would support that the animal meant to do it.

Best Costume — *sponsored by House Nightbreeze*
Judged on craft, concept, and the entrant's own evident tolerance for wearing it.

Best Vocalization — *sponsored by the Concordance*
Song, call, cry, or signal, whatever the entrant actually makes. Judged on control and carrying power.

Each entrant may be registered for up to three categories, no more.

Best in Show

Not a category of its own, Best in Show is chosen by the full judging panel from among this cycle's category champions. This cycle's purse is sponsored in full by Lord Wendell Carraway, of his own house's generosity and at considerable personal expense, a gesture the committee is given to understand he will mention unprompted at every opportunity between now and the judging.

Purse: 20,000 gp

Honorary, Not Judged

Longest Serving Ship's Animal
Presented, not competed for, to the entrant with the longest verifiable charter-service record. The committee asks only for the paperwork.

(continued: judges, the field, the halftime show, and the rest)

This Cycle's Judging Panel

Two panels of three, by lane. No judge crosses between them.

Physical Lane

Magistrate Yevelda Thorn

House Delverane

A silver elf of considerable age and considerably more opinions, fixated on symmetry to the point of personal eccentricity. Known to disqualify an otherwise flawless entrant for one crooked whisker.

Commodore (Ret.) Ossian Vale

House Stoneward

A retired Stoneward patrol officer, blunt and unsentimental, respects raw competence over any amount of polish. The panel's hardest mark by a wide margin, and everyone knows it.

Baroness Isolde Fenmark

independent

Old money, and proud of it. Cares more for bloodline and lineage than for anything an entrant actually does on the floor, a real source of friction with judges who value raw skill over pedigree.

Open Field Lane

Madam Quill

House Nightbreeze

A gnome barely taller than most of the entrants, easily delighted and impossible to win over twice with the same trick. Takes meticulous, illegible notes throughout every round.

Factor Renshaw Vell

House Vellum

Aging and exacting, judges every entrant against precedent and the official record. If it hasn't happened before, he wants to know why it's happening now.

Professor Aldric Wren

independent

A scholar by training, values originality above all else, and is genuinely hard to impress with anything that reads as derivative of a prior winner.

A fifth chair sits, as ever, at the head of the judging table. It is not filled.

How Each Category Is Actually Judged

For the record keepers among the crowd

Category	Check	Placed/Contender/Win
Best Presentation	Animal Handling	12 / 15 / 18
The Long Run	Acrobatics or Athletics	12 / 15 / 18
The Proving Round	Athletics or Acrobatics	13 / 16 / 19
Strength of Pull	Athletics	12 / 15 / 18
Fastest in Show	Acrobatics	12 / 15 / 18
The Cargo Run	Athletics	12 / 15 / 18
Most Convincing Trick	Performance	12 / 15 / 18
Best Costume	not rolled	judged on craft and tolerance alone
Best Vocalization	Performance	12 / 15 / 18

A failed check never means disqualification, only an ordinary showing, somebody has to finish the field. The committee asks that entrants and handlers alike remember this is exhibition, not survival.

This Cycle's Field

Thirty-one registered entrants, not counting late additions

Paragon, void-adapted mastiff (Verity Gilt's, three-time category champion)
Presentation, Pull, Proving

Kitty, tiny displacer beast kitten
Trick, Fastest

Bellows, juvenile hippogriff (famously fell asleep mid-judging and won anyway)
Presentation, Long Run

Needle, astral hamster
Trick, Vocal

Ribbon, corgi (entirely ordinary, and proud of it)
Costume, Trick

Soot, baby shadow dragon
Presentation, Proving, Fastest

Marmalade, orange tabby cat (utterly unbothered by any of this)
Vocal, Costume

Thistle, baby owlbear
Cargo Run, Pull, Long Run

Gravel, earth-touched mutt (working-class entrant)
Cargo Run, Pull

Whistler, space parrot (a gifted mimic)
Vocal

Captain, ship's cat
Fastest

Huckleberry, baby treant sapling
Presentation, Vocal

Vex, brass dragon hatchling (a past Best in Show winner, still competing)
Costume, Proving, Fastest

Oatmeal, golden retriever (zero threat, maximum warmth, last year's Best in Show)
Trick, Costume, Presentation

Scuttle, trained giant beetle
Cargo Run, Pull, Long Run

Pocket, tiny pseudodragon
Trick, Fastest

Bramble, blink dog (a past Best in Show winner the judges still resent)
Long Run, Fastest, Trick

Siren, kenku (mimics famous opera singers, uncannily well)
Vocal, Trick

Anchor, hauling mastiff (entirely ordinary, a past Best in Show winner ("the honest work year"))
Pull, Cargo Run, Proving

Dot, space guppy in a floating bowl (a past Best in Show winner ("nobody saw that coming"))
Presentation, Vocal

Juniper, baby pegasus
Presentation, Long Run

Chip, tressym (a winged cat, delighted by everything)
Fastest, Vocal

Bolt, baby griffon
Long Run, Proving

Mossy, myconid sprout (slow, patient, eerily charming)
Costume

Rattler, tamed giant constrictor
Pull, Cargo Run

Pippin, beagle (owned by a retired spacer who talks to him constantly)
Costume, Proving

Ember, fire-touched salamander
Proving, Cargo Run

Socks, black cat, white paws (a dockhand's pet)
Vocal, Fastest

Drum, baby bulette (surprisingly docile, an eccentric prospector's pet)
Cargo Run, Pull, Proving

(continued)

This Cycle's Field, continued

Wisp, faerie dragon (prone to illusory shortcuts the judges don't trust)
Costume, Long Run

(a rival worth watching follows overleaf)

A Rival Worth Watching

PLUME

Smoke Dragon Wyrmling · Handler: Barnaby Voss
Entered: Best Presentation, Most Convincing Trick, Best Costume

Visibly older and larger than most of this cycle's younger entrants, and entirely aware of it. Plume performs a showy flourish of smoke with every breath, whether or not anyone has asked to see one, and her handler narrates her accomplishments to anyone standing nearby, invited or not: "the Voss line has never placed outside the top three, you understand," delivered the same whether he is winning the conversation or not.

Condescending toward smaller, younger competitors in a way that reads as entirely practiced. The committee has fielded complaints. The committee has filed them.

(the halftime show follows)

Ten Years of Best in Show

Cycle	Champion	Notes
Last cycle	**Oatmeal**	*golden retriever, entirely ordinary, proof the show doesn't only reward the exotic*
2 cycles back	**Vex**	*brass dragon hatchling*
3 cycles back	**Bramble**	*blink dog, a win the judges still privately dispute*
4 cycles back	**Kitty**	*tiny displacer beast kitten*
5 cycles back	**Bellows**	*juvenile hippogriff, won asleep, a program legend*
6 cycles back	**Anchor**	*hauling mastiff, "the honest work year"*
7 cycles back	**Needle**	*astral hamster*
8 cycles back	**Marmalade**	*orange tabby, didn't seem to notice winning*
9 cycles back	**Scuttle**	*trained giant beetle*
10 cycles back	**Dot**	*a space guppy in a floating bowl, "the year nobody saw it coming"*

Several past champions remain active entrants this cycle, named above in the field roster. A veteran rarely retires quietly.

The Interval Spectacle

The Kindori Splash Show

This cycle's headline act: a trained, docile young pod performs in a purpose-built elemental-water arena, real water, real light, real motion. A rare, genuine wonder, and worth watching closely, not every spectacle at this Show is actually this honest about what it is.

Also Billed

The Windward Wings
A professional aerial troupe, pegasi, griffons, and hippogriffs flying a synchronized formation routine.

The Space Clowns
A slapstick act played, as always, slightly too straight to be entirely comfortable. The committee has engaged them again this cycle regardless.

(vendor row and on-site services follow)

Vendor Row and On-Site Services

Grooming stalls, a merchandise and souvenir row, and refreshment concessions run the length of the Pavilion's lower deck throughout the exhibition. The committee is pleased to announce this cycle's full vendor roster will be finalized and posted the morning of the first judging round, as always, somewhat later than promised.

Costume Commissions, On-Site

A limited number of booths are available this cycle for working costume commissions, taken and completed during the exhibition itself. Interested parties should inquire at the registration desk; booths are assigned first come, first served.

(notable attendees follow)

Who Else Is Here

Familiar Faces

The Fair Return crew
Marlow Albus's hauler, Tam Oakes among them this cycle with Puddle, a small, cheerfully affectionate plasmoid who has not yet chosen a category and may simply be here for the concessions.

The Weatheralls, of the Kettle
a pet of their own in tow, and almost certainly a song about it before the day's out.

Rimmon Vex, of the Cutlass Sunday
did not enter anything. Is here anyway. Nobody has yet worked out why.

Vaelren Windsong
with Fury, his unicorn phoenix, unannounced, as ever.

Also In Attendance

A name from the current top of the Manifest Board, here to be seen as much as to see anything. A great many smaller crews and solo entrants nobody's caught the names of yet, which is, for most of them, exactly the point of coming.

What's Actually Going On

Worth Knowing

A pickpocket ring has been working the crowd for at least two cycles now, low-stakes, rarely caught. At least one judge has been quietly approached this cycle by someone with an interest in a specific outcome. And at least one well-dressed stranger has spent more time watching the crowd than watching any single category, which is, in its own way, the most normal thing happening here.

Dirty Tricks, If Anyone's Tempted

The trick	To pull it off	To be caught
Bribe a judge	*Persuasion or Deception, DC 15*	*Insight, 13*
Swap a rival's grooming kit	*Sleight of Hand, DC 13*	*Perception, 12*
Plant a rumor about a rival	*Deception, DC 12*	*Insight, 14*
Misfile a rival's paperwork	*Sleight of Hand or Investigation, DC 14*	*Investigation, 15*

None of this harms an animal. That line holds absolutely, by committee rule and by the Show's whole character. Everything above is petty, and everyone involved knows it, and somehow that never stops anyone.

Entry & Conduct, the Short Version

- Entry is open to any companion creature accompanied by a sponsoring crew, house, or individual of record.
- Entrants must be collected, non-hostile, and under control at all times, judges' own discretion applies.
- Each entrant may be registered for up to three categories, no more.
- Sabotage, bribery, or interference with another entrant is grounds for immediate disqualification, should the committee ever actually catch anyone at it.
- The committee's judging decisions are final, binding, and occasionally inexplicable.

The International Space Dog Show thanks you for your continued, baffling enthusiasm.